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is called as **the axis**. Atlas is articulated with the occipital condyles.

The vertebral column protects the spinal cord, supports the head and serves as the point of attachment for the ribs and musculature of the back.

(c) The Sternum (Chest bone)

Sternum is a flat bone on the mid ventral line of the thorax. It provides space for the attachment of the thoracic ribs and abdominal muscles.

(d) The Rib cage

There are 12 pairs of ribs (Figure 9.9). Each rib is a thin flat bone connected dorsally to the vertebral column and ventrally to the sternum. It has two articulation surfaces on its dorsal end, hence called bicephalic. The first seven pairs of ribs are called '**true ribs'** or **vertebro–sternal ribs**. Dorsally they are attached to the thoracic vertebrae and ventrally connected to the sternum with the help of hyaline cartilages. The 8th, 9th and 10th pairs of ribs do not articulate directly with the sternum but joined with the cartilaginous (hyaline cartilage) part of the seventh rib. These are called **'false ribs'** or **vertebro-chondral ribs**. The last 11th and 12th pairs of ribs are not connected ventrally. Therefore, they are called as **'floating ribs'** or **vertebral ribs**. Thoracic

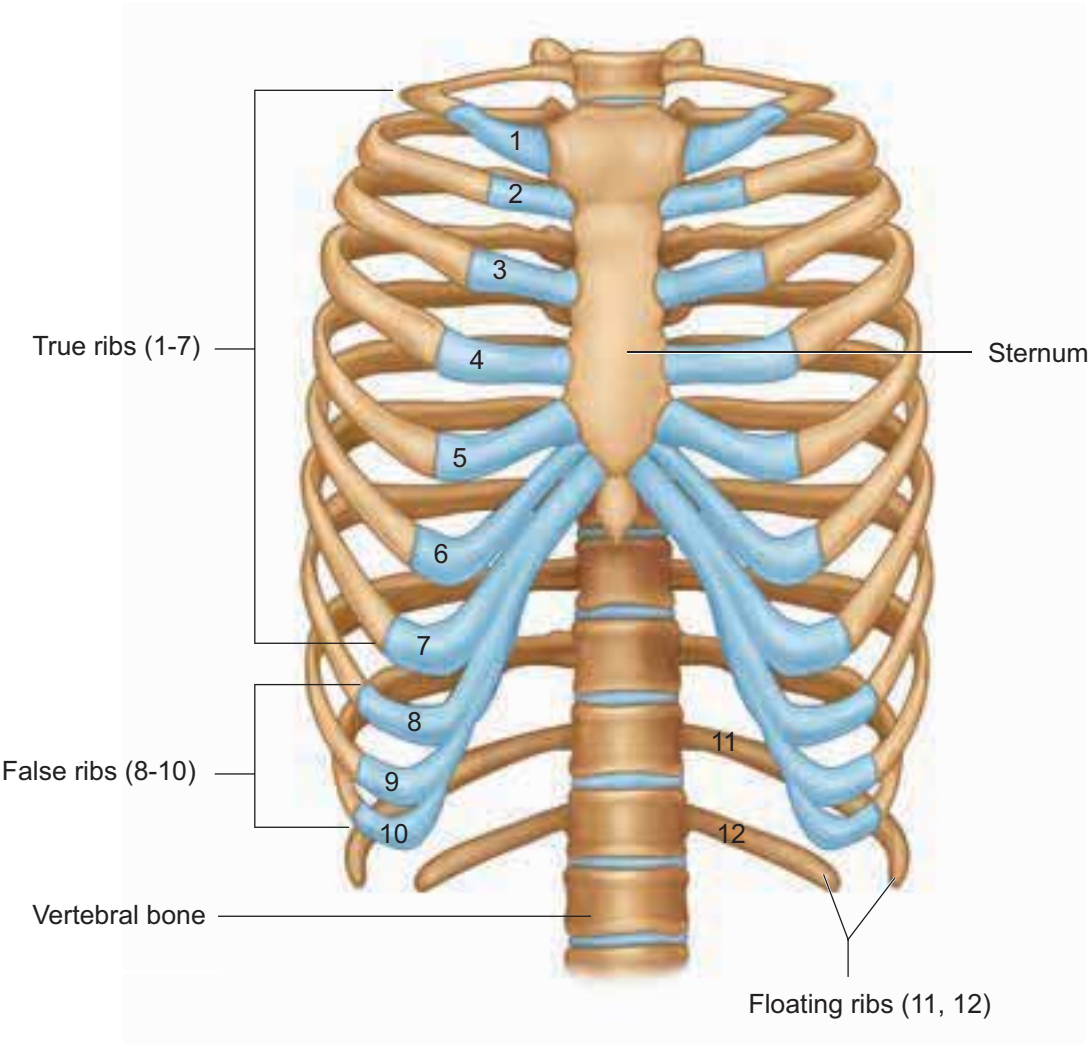

Figure 9 .9 Rib cage